

LECTURE NOTES • PROFESSIONAL MODULE 3

Guest Check-out and Settlement

Learning outcome	Focus
LO 3.1	Prepare documentation for the guest's departure
LO 3.2	Record the departure in the PMS and the guest database
LO 3.3	Handle guest complaints in line with professional ethics
Work placement	Apply LO 3.1–3.3 at the front desk; evidence in the placement log

DURATION

2 × 90 minutes

FORMAT

Lecture, practice, role play

MATERIALS

Slides, handout, folio samples

Photo: Basile Morin, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0. All guests, hotels and figures in the samples are fictional.

Preparing the guest's departure documents

Key points

- The folio is the legal and financial record of the stay. Every line must be explainable.
- Prepare the folio before the guest reaches the desk, so the conversation is short.
- Prepayments, deposits and discounts must appear as separate lines.
- The receipt total must equal the payment taken.
- File the closed registration card and the signed folio with the shift documents.

FORMULA

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Balance due} \\ &= \text{Total charges} \\ &\quad - \text{Prepayments} \\ &\quad - \text{Discounts} \end{aligned}$$

$$81,500 - 28,000 = 53,500 \text{ KZT}$$

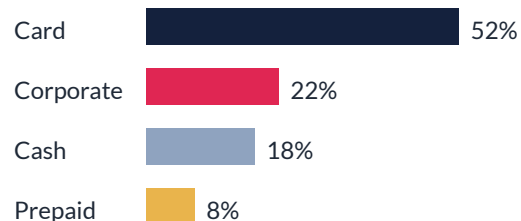
The document pack

Document	Purpose	Prepared by	Stored in
Final folio / invoice	Itemised charges for the guest	Receptionist	PMS + guest copy
Payment receipt	Proof of payment	Cashier-receptionist	Cash register + guest
Registration card	Closed with actual departure	Receptionist	PMS + paper file
Key card log	Cards issued and returned	Receptionist	Shift log
Minibar / damage report	Extra charges from the room check	Housekeeping	PMS + report file
Feedback form	Guest satisfaction record	Guest	Guest database

Common errors

- Charge posted to the wrong room
- Prepayment not applied
- Late check-out fee missing or duplicated
- Receipt issued before the folio is final

Settlement methods



Illustrative share of departures.

Recording the departure

Procedure in the PMS

- 1 Find the reservation in the departures list by room number or surname.
- 2 Verify the folio: all charges posted, nothing pending from restaurant or spa.
- 3 Post the payment with the correct method and amount; release any deposit hold.
- 4 Check the guest out. The folio closes with a zero balance.
- 5 Confirm the room status changes to Vacant Dirty and housekeeping is notified.
- 6 Update the guest profile: stay, spend, preferences, feedback and consent.

ROOM STATUS FLOW



Check-out dashboard • Wednesday, 07 Oct 2026

50

Departures

3 min 40 s

Average desk time

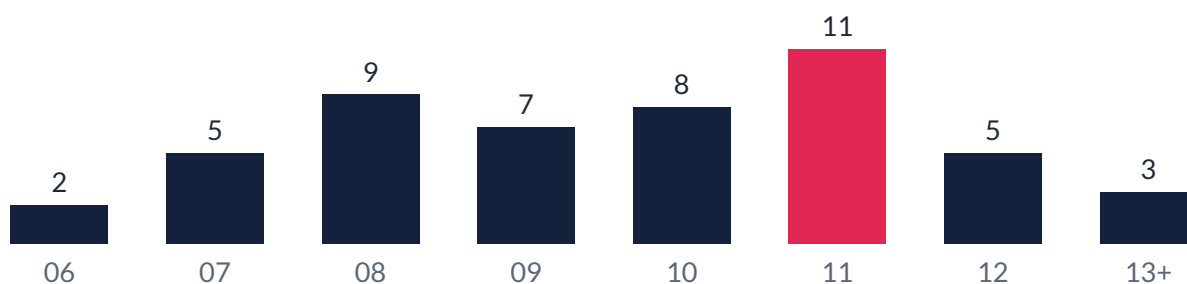
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Late check-outs

2

Disputed charges

Departures by hour



Illustrative data. Peak at 11:00: add a second agent on settlement.

Guest profile: update list

- ☐ Stay dates, room type and rate
- ☐ Total spend and payment method
- ☐ Preferences learned
- ☐ Complaints and compliments
- ☐ Contact details and consent

DATA PROTECTION

Collect only the data the hotel needs. Record marketing consent explicitly. Never keep card numbers in profile notes.

Handling guest complaints



The HEARD method

- 1 **Hear** — let the guest finish; do not interrupt or defend.
- 2 **Empathise** — show that you understand how the guest feels.
- 3 **Apologise** — for the experience, sincerely, without blame.
- 4 **Resolve** — offer a fix within your authority, or escalate.
- 5 **Diagnose** — log the cause so that it does not repeat.

SAY

“Thank you for telling me. I am sorry about the noise. Let me see what I can do for you now.”

AVOID

“That is not our fault.” “You should have told us earlier.” “That is the policy.”

Typical check-out complaints

Situation	First response	Escalate when
Charge the guest did not make	Check posting and room-check report; correct the folio	Cannot be verified at the desk
Late check-out fee disputed	Show the policy from the booking confirmation	Guest requests an exception
Noise or cleanliness during the stay	Apologise; check the complaint log	Compensation is requested
Long wait at check-out	Thank for patience; open a second desk	Guest may miss transport

ESCALATION LADDER



SAMPLE COMPLAINT LOG ENTRY

Ref	Room	Complaint	Action	Compensation	Status
C-0148	322	Corridor noise at 02:00	Apology; discount approved by duty manager	10% of rate	Closed

CASE: DEPARTURE FROM ROOM 312

Total charges 81,500 KZT. Online prepayment 28,000 KZT. Deposit hold 10,000 KZT. The guest pays 30,000 KZT in cash and the rest by card.

Tasks

- 1 Calculate the balance due.
- 2 Calculate the card amount.
- 3 Decide what happens to the deposit.
- 4 State how the cash drawer changes.
- 5 Write the PMS entries in order.

Answer key

1	$81,500 - 28,000 = 53,500$
2	$53,500 - 30,000 = 23,500$
3	Release the hold; it is not revenue
4	+30,000 in the shift cash
5	Cash 30,000 → card 23,500 → check-out → profile

Role play: disputed charge**GUEST**

Says the minibar was not used. Is in a hurry to reach the airport.

RECEPTIONIST

Uses HEARD, checks the room report, corrects or explains the charge.

OBSERVER

Scores each HEARD step and the time taken.

Assessment rubric

Criterion	Developing	Competent	Excellent
Documentation	Errors in the folio	Accurate folio and receipt	Accurate, prepared before the guest arrives
PMS and database	Missing profile updates	Complete check-out entry	Complete entry with useful preferences
Complaints	Defensive tone	Follows HEARD	Resolves and logs the cause

Work placement evidence

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Daily placement log with mentor signature | ☐ Complaint log entries you handled |
| ☐ Observed and independent check-outs | ☐ Mentor feedback form |
| ☐ Folio copies with personal data removed | ☐ Short reflection after each week |